Chapter 22 – A Brief History of the Curry

“It is a shame that Mama doesn't use the hundreds of other fruits and vegetables and spices available from around the world. If it isn't Indian, according to her, it isn't good.”

(Amulya Malladi, Indian author)

Since the very first steps taken by an outsider into the subcontinent of cardamom, turmeric, ginger, fenugreek, and an astounding assortment of herbs, aromatics, and natural preservatives, it was clear that India had something very special simmering in the kitchen. Much generalization has been made of these diverse and succulent dishes even since the days of trading along the Silk Road, but simply speaking, there is a collection of long-beloved ingredients used by most Indian cooks, whether they live in New Delhi or Chennai. These come together in a hundred different ways to create what we’ve come to describe as a “curry”: a heavily spiced dish cooked in the Indian style.

The famous curries of India are not without their own set of dining rules. Typically, Indians sit on the floor with their legs crossed to partake of a meal. It is a tradition that likely has its roots in the Vedic way of life since the posture mimics that of Sukhasan, an important Yogic pose. Instead of the high tables and chairs predominant in most Western dining rooms, the classical Indian dining area features a low table surrounded by several cushions. Diners use their hands and pieces of flatbread to eat.

There is a traditional collection of dining habits and manners that are expected to be used at the Indian table. It is considered customary at a formal table to sit down with freshly washed hands and keep the serving utensils from mixing in the dishes—the latter rule out of respect for the vegetarians among the diners. Washing your hands is not just important for one diner but for everyone at the table since it is customary to eat with one’s right hand. Passing food with the left hand helps to keep the dining area free of cross-contamination.

From the early Indus River Valley days, household living areas featured meals cooked from the bountiful crops of the floodplains. Harappan farmers grew dependent on a variety of grains that would remain the staple foods